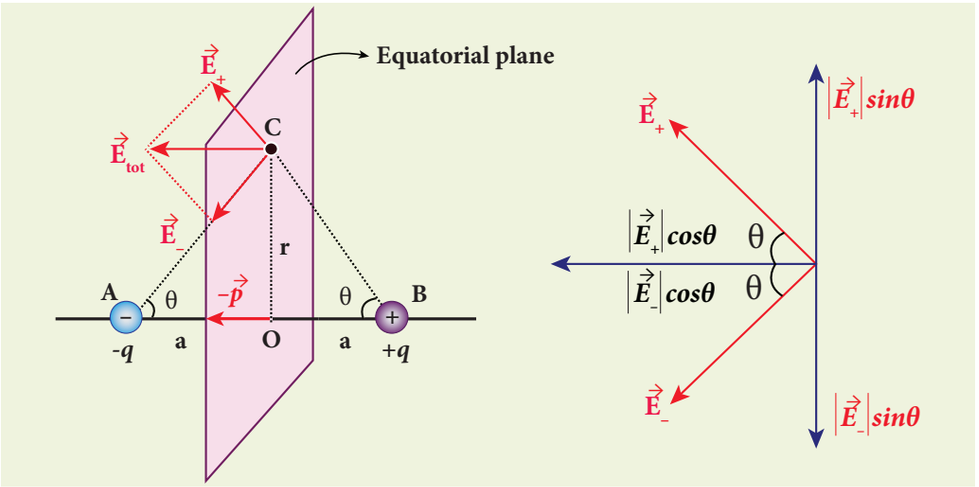


Figure 1.17 Electric field due to a dipole at a point on the equatorial plane

of $\vec{E}_+$ is along BC and the direction of $\vec{E}_-$ is along CA. $\vec{E}_+$ and $\vec{E}_-$ can be resolved into two components; one component parallel to the dipole axis and the other perpendicular to it. Since perpendicular components $|\vec{E}_+|\sin\theta$ and $|\vec{E}_-|\sin\theta$ are eqaul in magnitude and oppositely directed, they cancel each other. The magnitude of the total electric field at point C is the sum of the parallel components of $\vec{E}_+$ and $\vec{E}_-$ and its direction is along $-\hat{p}$ as shown in the Figure 1.17.

$$\vec{E}_{tot} = -|\vec{E}_+|\cos\theta\,\hat{p} - |\vec{E}_-|\cos\theta\,\hat{p} \qquad (1.18)$$

The magnitudes $\vec{E}_+$ and $\vec{E}_-$ are the same and are given by

$$|\vec{E}_+| = |\vec{E}_-| = \frac{1}{4\pi\epsilon_0}\frac{q}{\left(r^2+a^2\right)} \qquad (1.19)$$

By substituting equation (1.19) into equation (1.18), we get

$$\vec{E}_{tot} = -\frac{1}{4\pi\epsilon_0}\frac{2q\cos\theta}{\left(r^2+a^2\right)}\hat{p}$$

$$= -\frac{1}{4\pi\epsilon_0}\frac{2qa}{\left(r^2+a^2\right)^{\frac{3}{2}}}\hat{p}$$

since $\cos\theta = \dfrac{a}{\sqrt{r^2+a^2}}$

$$\vec{E}_{tot} = -\frac{1}{4\pi\epsilon_0}\frac{\vec{p}}{\left(r^2+a^2\right)^{\frac{3}{2}}}$$

since $\vec{p} = 2qa\hat{p}$ (1.20)

At very large distances ($r >> a$), the equation (1.20) becomes

$$\vec{E}_{tot} = -\frac{1}{4\pi\epsilon_\circ}\frac{\vec{p}}{r^3} \qquad (r >> a) \quad (1.21)$$

Important inferences

(i) From equations (1.17) and (1.21), it is inferred that for very large distances, the magnitude of the electric field at point on the dipole axis is twice the magnitude of the electric field at the point at the same distance on the equatorial plane. The direction of the electric field at points on the dipole axis is directed along the direction of dipole moment vector $\vec{p}$ but at points on the equatorial plane it is directed opposite to the dipole moment vector, that is along $-\vec{p}$.

(ii) At very large distances, the electric field due to a dipole varies as $\frac{1}{r^3}$. Note that for a point charge, the electric field

UNIT-1(XII-Physics_Vol-1).indd 23 14-02-2020 19:32:37